



CLASSIFIED PREVIEW

CODE CITIES · BOOK TWO

THE PARIS CODE

BY C.A. STERLING

CHAPTER ONE

*For dossier holders only.
Months before publication.
Do not share.*



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A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

WHY YOU'RE READING THIS BEFORE ANYONE ELSE.

You took the dossier. That puts you first.

What follows is Chapter One of *The Paris Code* in its working form — not a teaser, not an extract trimmed for a sales page, but the chapter as I sent it to my editor last month. There is one copy of it outside her drive: the one you are holding now.

The chapter was finished, like a great many of its sentences, in a small café in the 6th — on the rue de l'Ancienne-Comédie, opposite the cat I mention twice. The cat is real. The body in the back salon is not. Everything else in this room is to be taken on its merits.

If, when you finish, you feel that Westminster and Paris belong to the same shelf, that is the answer to a question I have been asking for two years.

Open it when you have an hour and a quiet room.

— *C.A. STERLING*

THE
PARIS CODE

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Multitude, solitude: termes égaux et convertibles pour le poète actif et fécond.

Multitude, solitude: equal and interchangeable terms for the active and fertile poet.

CHARLES BAUDELAIRE, 'LES FOULES', LE SPLEEN DE PARIS, 1869.

CHAPTER 1

LE PROCOPE, 08:11

Paris. Tuesday, 14 January. 08:11.

LE PROCOPE OPENED AT half past nine, but Yannick Bouchard always came in at eight to set the brasses, lay the cloths, and sweep the floor of last night's small disasters, and so at eleven minutes past eight on a Tuesday in January he was the first man in the city of Paris, apart from the man who had done it, to see the body on the banquette in the corner of the black salon and could not have. It was the banquette where, the legend ran, Robespierre had drunk coffee, and where Marat had eaten a meal he had not paid for, and where, in another century, a young lieutenant with bad teeth had argued with a tax official about the price of fish. The legend was mostly false and the brasses were polished anyway. Yannick polished brasses for a living. He liked Paris best at this hour, when its lies were still asleep.

The man on the banquette was not asleep.

He was sitting upright, very nearly correctly, with his hands placed on the cloth before him. His coat had been folded over the back of the seat. His face had the soft surprise of a man interrupted in the middle of a sentence. Yannick — who had served in Algeria for a year in 1962 and had seen, in his quiet later life, three drunks die in this same room — knew the difference between sleeping and not, and crossed himself in the way that the lapsed do, with one knuckle, on the inside of his sleeve.

Between the dead man's hands, neatly, on the cloth, was a coaster.

It was made of card thicker than the house coasters. Yannick lifted it without thinking, the way you straighten a fork. The coaster was printed in black ink with a crown. Seven points. The points were not engraved; they were drawn, with a pen that had gone over each stroke twice.

Below the crown, two words in small capitals.

EAT YOUR OWN.

Yannick did not understand them. He understood them later, but later, by then, had become a habit.

He put the coaster back exactly as he had found it. He was a man who had laid plates for forty-one years. He could replace a small object on a tablecloth from memory. He stood up.

The back salon at Le Procope is panelled in green and gold, with a low chandelier that hangs over the corner table like a slightly drunken witness. The chandelier was unlit. The shutters were closed against the Marais cold. Yannick crossed himself again, with two fingers this time, and walked to the front of house, where the telephone hung on its old brass cradle next to a framed black-and-white photograph of Sartre arguing with a waiter.

The line was answered on the third ring.

"Police, j'écoute."

"Ici Le Procope," said Yannick, and stopped. He had not, in forty-one years, ever needed to know which words came next. After a moment he said, in the voice you use when you are trying not to upset a child, *Il y a un mort dans mon café.*

Et un peu de papier dans ses mains.

A PIECE OF PAPER in his hands. Two pieces, in fact, if you counted the coaster between them. Yannick did. He gave the dispatcher the address. He gave the dispatcher the cross street. He gave the dispatcher his name and his telephone number and, when she asked, his date of birth, because France is a country in which even the smallest disaster begins with a date of birth.

He stood for a moment with his hand on the brass cradle. Outside, on the rue de l'Ancienne-Comédie, the morning was doing what Paris mornings do in January, which is to say it was occupying the street the way fog occupies a field — slowly, completely, with no announcement. A boy on a bicycle went past with a bag of bread. A cat looked at Yannick from the doorway of the chocolatier

opposite. The cat had been there for fourteen years; Yannick had never named her; she had never required it.

He went back into the salon.

The dead man was where he had been left. The coaster between his hands. The folded coat over the back of the banquette. Yannick, who was not a curious man by temperament, did not lift the coat.

If he had, he would have found, in the inside breast pocket, an envelope addressed in a small, exact, slightly old-fashioned hand to *Mademoiselle Eleanor Voss, Institut Culturel Britannique, 9 rue de Constantine, Paris VII*.

The envelope contained a receipt from this café. The date on the receipt was 14 July 1789.

The handwriting on the envelope was the same handwriting that had, three weeks earlier, signed a postcard in a Westminster pub.



The Brigade criminelle arrived at twenty-three minutes past eight.

There were three of them, two in plain clothes and one in uniform, and they came in through the front door without ceremony, the way people enter rooms they have entered before. Yannick had laid a clean cloth on the table by the door — a habit, not a service — and a thin grey woman in a navy coat folded her gloves onto it before she spoke to him.

"Monsieur Bouchard?"

"Yes."

"Inspector Hélène Marchetti. Don't touch anything else. Where is he?"

He pointed.

She did not look immediately. She looked first at Yannick — at his face, at his hands, at the line of his shoulders. He understood, dimly, that she was deciding whether he had killed the man and would have to be arrested before she could see the body, or whether he had not and could be left where he was. She decided in about three seconds. She crossed to the back salon without taking her coat

off.

Yannick did not follow.

Through the doorway he heard the brisk, almost cheerful exchange of voices that police make over a corpse — a question, a pause, a name; the click of a camera; photographes arrive dans dix minutes; the small, professional joke that someone makes to keep the room from going still. The uniformed officer, very young, came back through to ask Yannick whether he had a phone he could use without leaving the front door, and Yannick said yes, and gave him the brass cradle, and the boy was on it for several minutes in a low murmur Yannick did not quite catch.

The second man came in five minutes after that.

He came in without knocking. He shook no rain off his coat — there was no rain — but he carried himself the way men do when they have made it their business not to be seen carrying anything. He was somewhere in his fifties, neat, grey at the temples, with a wedding ring and a pin in his lapel and the kind of overcoat you order in the spring for the following winter. He held a small leather wallet open in his palm.

The young uniformed officer looked at the wallet, then at the man's face, then turned half a step out of his way.

"Inspector," the young officer called.

Marchetti came out of the back salon with her gloves on. She looked at the man with the wallet for slightly longer than necessary. Then she looked at the wallet itself, and the line of her mouth tightened by a degree that Yannick, who had read faces across his bar for forty-one years, registered with a small private interest.

"Ministry of Culture?" she said.

"Patrimoine. Préfecture liaison." The man's voice was light, pleasant, almost apologetic. "Madame, I'm sorry. There is an item on the body that falls within my brief. I'd like to retrieve it before your photographer arrives. It will take ninety seconds. The room is yours afterwards."

"What item?"

"An envelope. Inside breast pocket of the coat. The contents are not relevant to your investigation. The envelope itself is the property of a state cultural institution. I have a release form for the brigadier to countersign."

"For the body in my crime scene."

"For the envelope in the coat. The body is yours, Inspector. I am extremely sorry for the timing."

Marchetti held his eye for a long moment.

What Yannick would remember afterwards — what he would tell, eventually, to a tall young woman with very tired eyes who would arrive on his pavement that same afternoon — was that the inspector did not say yes and did not say no. She said: "Show me the wallet again." The man showed her the wallet again. She read it the way you read a menu in a restaurant you suspect of overcharging.

"Ninety seconds," she said. "You will not touch the body. You will lift the coat by the collar only. The photographer will document the envelope on the inside of the lining before you take it. Are we agreed?"

"With respect, Inspector—"

"Are we agreed?"

He inclined his head.

She watched him cross the room to the back salon. Yannick watched her watch him. There was a thin small pause — the room held its breath — and then Marchetti turned to the young officer and said, in a voice not pitched to be overheard, "Take his plate number. Take the colour of his car. Take whether his coat is wet or dry. Then tell me which ministry he is from. I would like to know."

The young officer nodded.

The man from Patrimoine was in the back salon for not quite ninety seconds. Yannick, from his post by the brass cradle, watched the angle of light shift inside the doorway as the man bent over the banquette. He heard the soft creak of folded wool being unfolded. He heard the small dry sound of paper being slid out of paper. He heard nothing more.

The man came back through the room with an envelope held flat between two fingertips and the slightly preoccupied face of a man counting silently to himself. He inclined his head, again, to the inspector, who did not return it. He did not look at Yannick.

He was gone before the photographer arrived.



It was, in the end, the absence of the postcard that Yannick would not forget.

There had been no postcard. He understood that. There had only been an envelope inside a coat which had now ceased, by ninety seconds of administrative magic, to exist. But the way the man from Patrimoine had carried the envelope out of the room — flat, between two fingertips, the address turned inward against his palm — had reminded Yannick, with the small unreasonable clarity of old age, of the way another man, twenty years before, had carried something out of his old café in the 11th, before Yannick had moved to Le Procope, and had told him afterwards, with great courtesy, that there had been nothing on the counter all evening.

Yannick had agreed then. He did not, this time, agree.

When Marchetti came back to ask him whether he had seen anything in the dead man's possession before her arrival — anything at all, no matter how small — Yannick said, carefully:

"He had a coat over the back of the seat. The man from the ministry took an envelope out of the inside pocket. Before the photographer."

Marchetti looked at him.

"You are sure?"

"I am sure."

"What did the envelope say?"

"I did not read it. I did not touch it."

"Was anything written on the outside?"

Yannick thought.

"A name," he said. "I think a name. In a small hand. Old-fashioned. The kind of hand my grandmother wrote in." He shook his head. "I cannot tell you what the name was, Madame. I would not invent."

Marchetti wrote that down. She did it without comment. When she put the notebook away she touched Yannick on the wrist, lightly, once, in the brisk way a doctor touches a patient who has been brave.

"Stay at the front of the house, Monsieur. I will speak with you again."

She went back into the salon.

The cat from across the street, who had been there for fourteen years and never been named, considered Yannick through the window of the chocolatier and did not approve of his morning. The boy with the bag of bread did not come back. Outside, on the rue de l'Ancienne-Comédie, the slow January fog was occupying the street the way it had always occupied the street, and the city of Paris went on conducting itself in the manner to which the city of Paris was accustomed, which is to say with the air of having seen this before and having decided, on balance, not to be impressed.

Inside, in the green and gold panelled room beyond the brass cradle, a chandelier that had not been lit hung over a dead man whose envelope was already in another building. The corner banquette where Marat had not eaten a meal he had not paid for held, very nearly correctly, the body of a man who, until ten minutes earlier, had been somebody's son.

On the pavement opposite, parked half on the curb, a black Citroën with its engine still running pulled away into the fog.

Only Yannick saw it go.

AFTERWORD TO CHAPTER ONE

FROM THE AUTHOR

This chapter was written over the autumn of 2024, mostly in the back salon of the café it describes — not at the corner banquette, which is, as Yannick says, the one tourists ask for and cannot have, but at the small table by the door, where the brass cradle is real and the cat across the street is too. The handwriting on the envelope is the handwriting that signs the postcard in Chapter 32 of *Westminster*.

Chapter Two, working title *Gare du Nord*, 09:42, picks the story up nine and a half hours later, on the Eurostar platform at the moment Eleanor Voss steps off the train. You will not have it long. Thank you for reading this one first.

— C.A. STERLING



The Paris Code — declassified [Month Year].

Dossier holders are first.

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